Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Rudyard Kipling's "The Power of the Dog"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the theme(s) of Joseph Rudyard Kipling's "The Power of the Dog" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
couplet,
imagery,
meter,
metonymy,
onomatopoeia,
parenthetical,
persona,
polyptoton,
quatrain,
refrain,
rhetorical question,
rhyme,
stigmatism,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

A fairly straightforward approach to a discussion of the theme of Kipling's lyric poem suffices. The poem sorts out as an admonition advising the listener to refrain from acquiring a pet, specifically a puppy—the reasoning forcefully introduced in the opening two lines: "There is sorrow enough" in our "natural" lives (lived with other humans) without our ensuring guaranteed additional sorrow—self-inflicted—brought on by the loss of a pet. The balance of the poem acts as logical support for the advice that is essentially philosophical.